Understanding IMO FAL Forms (1–7): A Complete Guide for Ship Operators and Agents

What Are FAL Forms?

FAL Forms are standardized documents established by the International Maritime Organization (IMO) under the Convention on Facilitation of International Maritime Traffic (FAL Convention).

They streamline the reporting procedures required when a vessel arrives at or departs from a port.

The goal of FAL documentation is to reduce administrative burden, enhance compliance, and ensure efficient communication between ships, port authorities, customs, and immigration.

Why FAL Forms Matter

Ports around the world rely on FAL forms to:

Verify ship, crew, and cargo information

Support customs and immigration processes

Enhance port safety and security

Ensure compliance with international regulations

Even when submitted electronically, the legal responsibility remains with the vessel's Master, though agents commonly prepare the forms.

Overview of IMO FAL Forms

FAL Form 1 – General Declaration

Provides essential details about the ship and voyage, including:

Vessel name, flag, IMO number

Voyage number

Last and next ports

Master's details

Summary of cargo

Used by: Port authority & customs.

FAL Form 2 – Cargo Declaration

Lists all cargo carried on board, including:

Description of goods

Quantities and weights

Bills of lading

Shipper and consignee details

Used by: Customs & port authorities.

FAL Form 3 – Ship's Stores Declaration

Declares all stores kept for ship's use:

Fuel and oils

Food supplies

Bonded items (alcohol, cigarettes)

Used by: Customs.

FAL Form 4 – Crew's Effects Declaration

Lists personal belongings of each crew member such as:

Cash

Electronics

Personal valuables

Any dutiable goods

Used by: Customs & immigration.

FAL Form 5 – Crew List

A detailed list of the entire crew:

Full names and ranks

Nationality

Passport/Seaman's Book number

Date/place of birth

Used by: Immigration & port authorities.

FAL Form 6 – Passenger List

Required if passengers are on board. Includes:

Names

Passport details

Ports of embarkation/disembarkation

Used by: Immigration.

FAL Form 7 – Dangerous Goods Manifest

Mandatory when carrying hazardous materials. Shows:

UN number

IMDG class

Proper shipping name

Packaging group

Onboard stowage location

Used by: Port authority, fire brigades, safety officers.

Electronic Submission (Single Window)

Many ports now accept or require electronic FAL submission, reducing paper documentation and speeding up clearance.

However, the content requirements remain the same, and the Master is still accountable for accuracy.

Who Completes the FAL Forms?

Ship's agent generally prepares and submits the forms.

Master must verify, approve, and sign (physically or electronically).

Some ports require additional documentation, such as health declarations or security certificates.

Do CERs Replace FAL Forms?

No. CERs (Crew Entry Records) may supplement or partially replace immigration requirements in some ports, but they do not replace IMO FAL Forms 1–7.

Conclusion

The IMO FAL Forms remain a fundamental part of maritime reporting and port clearance.

Whether submitted on paper or electronically, accurate completion ensures:

Efficient port operations

Faster crew processing

Full regulatory compliance

Ship operators and agents should maintain familiarity with each form and stay informed about local port requirements.